Ursula von der Leyen to visit Black Sea amid wave of deadly drone attacks

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Ursula von der Leyen to visit Black Sea amid wave of deadly drone attacks
By Antoaneta Roussi, Gerardo Fortuna, Jacopo Barigazzi · Nov 6, 2026, 12:05 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen is slated to visit Bulgaria and Romania next week, following a series of drone attacks on Black Sea vessels that have heightened security tensions along NATO's eastern flank.

According to three European Commission officials familiar with the plans, von der Leyen is expected to travel to both countries after attending the COP climate summit in Turkey. "It's now the deadliest shipping route in the world," said one of the officials, who was granted anonymity to speak about security-related plans.

At least seven commercial vessels were reportedly struck by drones in the Black Sea last month, leaving two sailors dead and at least 25 missing. The attacks, which Romania blames on Russia, have brought the violence of the war in Ukraine dangerously close to NATO territory.

Romania has warned that the strikes are part of Moscow's escalating aggression against Ukraine, while Bulgaria has stopped short of formally blaming Moscow, referring instead to drones coming from "an eastern direction."

The security concerns reached Bulgaria's shores Friday, when a local resident discovered a drone washed up near the coastal town of Shabla. The aerial vehicle appeared to have been carried ashore by the sea, said the municipality's mayor, Mariyan Zhechev. The drone's origin and whether it was connected to the recent attacks on commercial shipping have not been established.

Details of von der Leyen's itinerary remain scarce, with some European commissioners' offices unaware of the planned trip. It is also unclear whether she will be accompanied by anyone else such as European Council President António Costa or EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas.

The plans come as NATO allies step up surveillance over the Black Sea following the attacks on commercial shipping. Italian, British and American reconnaissance aircraft were spotted conducting simultaneous missions over the region Tuesday, according to Bulgarian broadcaster bTV, while France has extended the deployment of a maritime patrol aircraft in Romania.

The deteriorating security situation is also prompting diplomatic efforts to protect commercial shipping. Speaking at Saturday's G20 foreign ministers' meeting in Atlanta, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said India and Turkey had put forward proposals to help grain-carrying vessels navigate the Black Sea

safely amid the continuing Russia-Ukraine war.

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